

37 normative property. The story cannot be that we were exposed to verbal exhortations in previous lives and thus became aware of to-be-done-ness. For that story does not explain why we only selectively remember to-be-doneness but not the linguistic expressions that refer to it or the relevant semantic relations. And, if we could remember not only to-be-done-ness, but also these expressions and their semantic relations with to-be-done-ness, then it would be hard to explain why we ever need to learn what these expressions mean. Thus, the epistemological mystery around to-be-done-ness remains unsolved.⁵⁸ Given this problem, Maṇḍana could insist that the object of pratibhā, i.e., to-be-done-ness, is nothing other than the property of being a means to a desired end. As Maṇḍana himself notes, his own theory—on which an awareness of this latter property gives rise to actions—does no worse than his opponent's in explaining how children and other languageless animals perform various skilled activities without any instruction or antecedent observation. He says: Just as [on your view] temporally remote language is the cause of pratibhā in children, birds, etc. due to the continuity of impressions, why shall it not be accepted that the same kind of awareness with respect to a means is the cause of undertaking or refraining from action due to the continuity of impressions? And differences with respect to species, etc. awaken the impressions left by the awareness of a means just as they awaken the linguistic impressions [on your view].⁵⁹ The point is that we do not need linguistic impressions to explain how languageless animals and children perform various actions without any instruction or antecedent observation. We can simply assume that such actions are produced by an awareness of those actions as means to desired ends. How does that arise? Just as the opponent appeals to linguistic impressions to explain the awareness of to-be-done-ness, so also can we appeal to impressions or memory traces left in our past lives by the awareness of the relevant actions as means to desired ends. So, there is no need for us to think that the object of pratibhā is anything other than the property of being a means to a desired end. Let us take stock. Maṇḍana has shown two things so far. On the one hand, he has noted, using his opponent as a mouthpiece, that we sometimes act just on the basis of the judgement that something is to be done, without considering explicitly whether that action is a means to any end we desire. Cases of skilled unreflective activities performed by children and animals, e.g., suckling, birdsong, etc., support this intuition. On the other hand, we have no good epistemological story about how we become aware of to-be-done-ness at least if the property is irreducibly normative. Then, the only way of preserving the intuitions about cases of skilled

⁵⁸ VVS §11.9, 563.9-20 and VVMG 213.4-6 and 214.1-4. ⁵⁹ VVS 11.6, 540.24-25-541.1-2: śiśuśakuntādīnāṃ yathā viprakṛṣṭaḥ śabda nimittam bhāvanānugamāt pratibhāyāḥ tathā tādrśam evopāyajñānaṃ pravṛttinivṛttinibandhanaṃ bhāvanānugamamukhena kiṃ neṣyate | jātiviśeṣādayaś ca śabdabhāvanāyā ivopāyajñānabhāvanāyāḥ prabodhakāḥ | For a variant, see VVMG 202.4-6.